

Crystal Clear

A pop single, a music film and an installation, made from freshwater research

Dr WELI · Weliton Menário Costa · scientist-artist, Sydney · drweli.com/portfolio/ars-biologica

€24,000

15,000 PRODUCTION · 6,000 FEE · 3,000 TRAVEL

THE ARTISTIC CONCEPT

Science speaks about reality. Art translates the emotion of that reality through the artist's angle. Reading a paper for its emotional hook means finding the opening where something in the findings opens an emotion I can enter and express what I feel in front of it. Not a point about environmental activism: an opening onto human life.

Worked example (Shabarova et al. 2021, *Nature Microbiology* 6:479): one measured quantity returned to its earlier level before the living community did, so a system can pass the check people run on it and still be short of what lived in it. *Clarity is what a person can check by looking. Recovery is not. This demonstrates method. The finding is chosen with the scientists first.*

MY PRACTICE

I designed the experiments, collected field data on wild kangaroos, ran the analysis and published it in *Behavioral Ecology*, then turned the same research into music, dance, performance and video.

- › **Kangaroo Time**, written and directed by me. AAAS Dance Your PhD Overall Winner 2024. 238+ media features, five continents
- › **Cabra da Peste**, commissioned to open the XLI Encontro Anual de Etologia
- › One of **30 shortlisted worldwide**, Falling Walls Engage 2025
- › Visiting Fellow, ANU Centre for the Public Awareness of Science. Studio: WildWooHoo. Genre: **sci pop**, defined in a citable paper
- › **5+ years of practice**: performed through the doctorate 2017-2021; a field photograph of mine is published and credited in my 2021 ANU thesis

WHAT I OFFER

Engagement is the differentiator. The form carries real science and opens participation at several levels at once, which is what most people name as the measure of a successful event.

- › **Scientists**: during concept development, and in building the structure for using the material they send
- › **Community**: dance, performance, paid roles in the film
- › **Public**: immersion in the making, on social media and inside the installation
- › **After**: a released pop song that keeps travelling

HOW THE SCIENTISTS ARE INVOLVED

1	Conversation before any artistic decision. What would you most want a stranger to know?	They choose the finding with me
2	I read the chosen paper twice: for the central problem, and for the human opening	Correct anything I misread
3	I ask for existing, cleared material. No new field campaign	Bioacoustic records or any sound from their study systems; images or video of patterns, organisation and structures; and anything they find beautiful or strange in their own material
4	We talk through why they chose each item	One call, a sentence on each
5	I write. Recordings become sound; patterns become tempo and choreography; images become film and room	Nothing
6	Three reviews: premise and demo, sources and credits, rough cut and captions	Veto over the science

ACTIVITIES AND TIMELINE

Jan-Mar 27 remote	Kick-off; research chosen together; material request issued. Framework + videos 1-3
Apr-Aug 27 remote	Material exchange; songwriting; 3 Sydney studio days , one spent running the concept through their recordings and patterns. Master and stems before filming ; videos 4-8
Sep 27 on site	Scientist and site meetings; public listening and movement lab ; rehearsal; film shot with local cast ; video 9
Oct 27-Feb 28 remote	Edit; scientist review of facts, captions, credits; installation build and testing. Your required written phase-two proposal ; videos 10-13
Mar 28 on site	Install, test, screen, public conversation, document, strike. Videos 14-15

Content is an activity, not a by-product: 15 captioned process videos Jan 2027 to festival close, plus cleared stills to České Budějovice 2028 at each phase.

PRODUCTION BUDGET · €15,000

Recorded pop single, Sydney, 3 days	3,020
Czech music film, 2 shoot days, edit, grade	2,300
Full-run AV: screens, listening points, projection	2,100
Czech installation designer and lead	1,600
Movement lead + 3 paid adult performers	1,700
Structure, surfaces, fabrication, fire treatment	800
Fifteen process videos	700
2027 public lab + 2028 engagement	550
Czech language, liaison, access, subtitling	650
Research material licences	250
Contingency, 8.9%	1,330

Total, sums exactly to the cap 15,000

Two lines carry published prices. **No supplier is commissioned and none has quoted.**

OUTCOMES

- › An original pop single, released, that outlives the festival
- › A music film to industry standards, with performers from the town
- › An installation at Ars Biologica 2028 showing the research, the material and the translation
- › A documented public lab (2027) and a public conversation (2028)
- › 15 process videos and cleared stills for the host

IMPACT AND RISKS

⚠ **The first stay falls before the song exists.** I request the compulsory Jan-Mar period **remotely**, and use the **optional September stay to film**, arriving with the song mastered. Filming then happens once, with the local cast and the scientists available in the same weeks. **This is what makes the schedule land in time.** Needs written approval.

- › **€3,000 cannot fund three crossings.** The call sets 2-5 Budweis trips plus 2 to Ars Electronica; from Sydney only the bottom of that range is fundable. Two stays, both Linz visits by rail from Budweis inside them. Fallback: fly Brazil-Prague off an August 2027 family trip
- › **AV and the film are unquoted.** Named fallbacks; both re-costed in the Oct/Nov 2027 proposal
- › **Scientists are advisers.** Never unpaid crew, never presumed co-authors
- › **Accuracy:** three review gates with a veto; every source labelled with author, recordist, place and date; a recording of water is never labelled as a microorganism's voice